On the discussion questions regarding Russell's 'On Denoting' (December 3, 2025)

Here are a couple of thoughts and observations on the discussion questions. As always, comments are welcome!

All groups:
"Is there such a thing as knowledge by acquaintance? If so: of what kind of entities (objects, properties, events, states, …) is such knowledge possible? If not: why not?"

If we think of knowledge as involving beliefs that can be shared, does that rule out knowledge by acquaintance? Or can we think of ways of sharing beliefs that do not involve description (in language or otherwise)? It would appear that merely supplying two individuals with the same input (sensory or otherwise) is not sufficient for saying that they share knowledge of that input. To the extent that some form of conceptualization is involved that by itself introduces a vector for individuals to differ. An obvious case: we can both listen to the same lecture and come away with different beliefs about the subject matter. Less obvious, but still not excluded: we can both look out the window and form different beliefs about the weather.

That being said, there is a strong inclination to consider knowledge, and belief in general, to be something that can be shared among individuals, if not in fact, then at least in principle. Of course, we all have our own little secrets, things that (we believe) only we know, but the point about secrets is that they need to be kept, i.e., we need to actively make sure that they do not become shared. So, whatever a secret is, it is something that can be shared, even if it isn't. This makes knowledge and belief essentially social notions, that make sense only against the background of a community of individuals that, at least in principle, can share beliefs, including those that count as knowledge. One reason to think so is provided by Donald Davidson, who distinguishes between convictions and beliefs, and who argues that the distinctive feature of beliefs is that they presuppose the concept of error: a belief is something that we can err in holding, and we acknowledge that possibility of erring).[1] But error itself is a concept that extends beyond the realm of the purely individual, the realm of the private, as is forcefully maintained by Wittgenstein in his famous "private language argument.[2]

This then raises a further question about the distinction between knowledge by acquaintance and knowledge by description. The latter, being tied to some shared form of conceptualisation and representation, such as a natural language, is clearly and firmly located in the social realm. The former, however, seems to allow for the possibility of purely private content. However, in view of the considerations above, it seems that there is ample reason to maintain that such purely private content (if it exists at all) by itself does not form a belief, and, *a forteriori*, does not constitute knowledge. In the realm of acquaintance there seems to be no way to distinguish between belief and illusion, thus reinforcing the Davidsonian point about the intricate relation between belief and error, and the social nature of concept of error and the practice of error detecting.

This indicates that knowledge is a social concept, minimally in the sense that knowledge can be shared among different individuals. In theories of social epistemology this dimension is extended to cover also how knowledge is acquired and justified, but for the purpose of what is at stake here, viz., the question whether there is such a thing as knowledge by acquaintance, it suffices to focus on knowledge's potential to be shared. To be shared means at least two things: it functions

[1] See his 'Rational Animals', *Dialectica*, 36(4), 1982, pp. 317-327. (Reprinted in *Subjective, Intersubjective, Objective*. Clarendon, Oxford, 2001)
[2] See *Philosophical Investigations*, section 243 ff.

in basically the same way for different individuals; and it can be communicated. These two characteristics don't sit very well with the very concept of acquaintance, which is strictly tied to an individual, and which defies expression in language.

(We should note that the latter feature, viz., inexpressibility in language, seems one that also applies to some extent to so-called 'know-how'. Knowing how to ride a bike, for example, is something that does not lend itself to being captured fully in purely verbal terms. However, know-how *is* communicable: by means of showing, practicing and correcting, and, indeed also sometimes by some additional linguistic instruction. These are means of communication that appear to be lacking in the case of acquaintance.)

Note that this does not force us to deny that acquaintance is real. That we stand in a particular relation to our sensory impressions, for example, seems plausible. But the question that is at stake is whether that particular, individual-specific relation to that kind of individual-located content is to be classified as 'knowledge'. And that seems doubtful. Of course, one could reply that it is knowledge of a different kind. But, first of all, that seems a mere semantic move, and second and more importantly, it does not make clear what the connection between this type of knowledge and the ordinary type is. And note that this is crucial for Russell, who wants to ground knowledge by description in knowledge by acquaintance. So, an account of how the two are related should be forthcoming. But how incommunicable, 'private' experience can ground communicable, shared experience is not obvious.

A final note on the type of objects/experience that is supposed to be what we can have knowledge of by being acquainted with it. The standard examples are sense data, i.e., the visual, auditory, tactile and olfactory contents that are delivered by our sensory organs. Proprioception seems another source of this kind of content. And yet other examples are mental states and experiences, such as emotions, moods, desires, and corporal sensations, such as pain. There is a sense in which these entities are indeed 'private': they are located in, and in that sense are confined to, an individual. But note that despite that these are all things that we can communicate. That we are in pain, or that we look up and notice the blue sky, is perfectly shareable: we can tell others about it, discuss it, doubt or confirm it, and so on. Thus, what look like purely private entities turn out to have an intrinsically shared, social dimension as well. Reflection on how we acquire the concepts and expressions involved strengthens this. We learn colour differences through learning the colour vocabulary of our mother tongue; we learn to differentiate between various emotional states by learning how to describe, communicate and discuss them; and so on.

Group 1:
"Is there a kind of knowledge (or knowledge of a kind of entities) that depends essentially on description? If so: what kind? If not: why not?"

One area where description appears to be absolutely essential is mathematics. Perhaps having different views on the nature of mathematical entities makes a slight difference, but certainly for constructivists the very essence of mathematics depends on our ability to come up with descriptions of mathematical entities and their properties and relations, and to constructively prove their existence. Platonism, which assumes that mathematical entities are there independently of our knowledge of them, opens the possibility of a more direct form of access, viz., through some form of intuition, a kind of intellectual 'seeing'. There have been people who claim to be able to 'see' mathematical entities and their properties and relations in such a direct way. And intuition definitely plays a role in mathematical practice. But the very concept of proof, the ability not just to have a hunch or a gut feeling, but to actually prove to yourself *and to others*

that a particular mathematical entity exists, that a specific theorem holds, all that depends on description.[3]

Taking our lead from the case of mathematics, it seems definitely plausible that in practice description is essentially involved in almost anything that we investigate and obtain knowledge of. One reason is that basically all of science uses mathematics in some form or other. And another reason is that the alternative is implausible, if not impossible. To deny that description plays an essential role in some epistemological domain means to claim that knowledge in that domain can be framed in a language which uses only names (for objects, properties and relations). But what is involved in giving names? Identifications of the objects, properties, and relations named. So, we need to investigate how identification proceeds. It seems there are two main ways: via ostension, and via description. If we can argue that not all entities can be identified via ostension, then we can conclude that we always also need description, so descriptions are essential after all. A famous argument against the "grounding" role of ostensions can be found in Wittgenstein's *Philosophical Investigations* (section 27 ff.).

Group 2:
"From a linguistic point of view there is a tension between the contextual nature of Russell's analysis of descriptions and the principle of compositionality. Discuss. Are there other reasons to adhere to compositionality and reject the contextual analysis?"

From a linguistic perspective definite descriptions are constituents. So, *if* we maintain the principle of compositionality, then it seems we need to assign independent meanings to definite descriptions, like we do to other constituents: proper names, verbs, nouns, adverbs, … However, the question is what is the status of the compositionality principle. Is it akin to a basic law of linguistics, something that describes a fundamental property of natural languages? Or is it more of a methodological nature, i.e., a principle that guides the way in which we formulate descriptions of languages and linguistic theories? In both cases there is a tension with Russell's contextualist analysis of descriptions, but in each case that tension is of a different nature. If compositionality is akin to an empirical law, then Russell's analysis is wrong, at least from the perspectives of natural language semantics. But if compositionality is a methodological guideline, then Russell's contextualist approach is not wrong, just different.

Two additional observations. First all, we should note that for Russell the connection with linguistics is not particularly relevant: his concerns are philosophical and logical, not empirical. Second, we do well to note that there are certainly reasons not to embrace compositionality as an empirical principle also from purely linguistic perspectives. These reasons can be labelled as related to 'holism' and '(radical) contextualism'.

'Holism' refers to observations concerning language acquisition and language use. If we look at how children acquire their first language we can observe that it is sentences, not words, that are their primary material. The bulk of the linguistic material that children take their cues from consist of sentences. It is only rarely that adults interact with young children using only words. And despite the fact that children start in a 'one-word sentence' stage, it is important to note that even such word-like utterances are from a communicative point of view sentences. Likewise, if

[3] This is not to deny that experience has no role to play in the constitution of our mathematical skills. Teaching mathematics, developing these skills arguably depends on shared ways of experiencing the world. But there seems to be a qualitative difference between the basic 'counting and measuring' that we all come to share in the course of our cognitive development and the actual employment of complicated mathematical theories. See J. Stam, M. Stokhof, M. van Lambalgen, 'Naturalising mathematics? A Wittgensteinian perspective'. *Philosophies*, 7(4), 2022, for an overview of relevant research and discussion.

we look at how language is used by competent speakers, again the bulk of it consists of sentences. They may be incomplete, or very short, but communication is never a matter of uttering words. It is sentences that do the job. So, the basic unit when learning a language and when using it, is that of the sentence. That puts the principle of compositionality in a different perspective.

The second reason, labelled '(radical) contextualism' is aimed at the assumption of compositionality, viz., that words (along with particular other morphological entities) have meaning all by themselves. Based on considerations regarding the way in which words can take on different meanings in different contexts of use, some have argued that this assumption cannot be maintained: there is no way to assign meanings to words prior to, i.e., independent of, their use in communicative situations.[4] And the use of words is always part of the use of larger wholes, viz., sentences.

Group 3:
"Recall that Quine's analysis of ontological commitment uses Russell's theory of description. Is that necessary? Or could one maintain Quine's analysis also with another analysis of descriptions? Why (not)?"

Quine's criterion, "To be is to be the value of a variable", locates ontological commitments in the quantificational apparatus of a language. He applies Russell's theory of descriptions not just to relegate definite descriptions to that part of a formal language, but also to do the same with proper names. That is a move that Russell also advises: on his view all normal proper names are disguised descriptions, and descriptions are analysed by means of the quantificational apparatus of the language.

Russell has independent reasons for his treatment of proper names, that have to do with his aim to ground knowledge by description ultimately in terms of knowledge by acquaintance. Quine's motivation is different: his aim is to make ontological commitment transparent. But does he need to follow Russell's lead for that?

Consider an atomic sentence containing a constant *a*, e.g., *Fa*, and the equivalent existentially quantified formula *Ex(Fx & x=a)*. (Using '*E*' for the existential quantifier, and '*&*' for conjunction.) If the use of a proper name *A*, represented in the formal language by the individual constant *a*, comes with an existential commitment, viz., to the existence of an object named '*A*', then this commitment is adequately captured by this existentially quantified formula using Quine's criterion. We could go a step further and use constants only in identities of the form '*x=c*', and no longer use them to form other atomic sentences. What we end up with is equivalent, in a sense that can be made precise, with the usual system, except that Quine's criterion now captures all the ontological commitments that come with proper names, without the need to eliminate names by re-analysing them as definite descriptions in Russell's fashion.

Note also that Quine's 'last stance', –viz., that of using tailor-made predicates, such as 'pegasises', that can be used to provide descriptive content where a more regular description is lacking–, comes basically to the same thing: '*x=p*', with *p* the constant associated with 'Pegasus', is a propositional function, i.e., a logical expression that expresses the property of 'being Pegasus', to which the property of 'pegasising, is supposed to correspond uniquely.

[4] See for example Charles Travis, *Occasion-sensitivity: Selected essays*, OUP, Oxford, 2008. More on Travis in the notes of next week.

Group 4:
"What reasons are there to maintain bi-valence? Can you think of possible exceptions, i.e., phenomena that have a logic that does not satisfy the principle of excluded middle?"

The principle of excluded middle, i.e., the principle that *A or not-A* holds for any sentence *A*, seems to be one of the most basic logical laws. It captures, or so it seems, the essence of truth and falsity: what *A* asserts is either true or false, in which case the sentence that asserts that *A* is false, viz., *not-A*, is true.

One way to explain that intuition is to point out that this is how things work: it is reality that determines whether an assertion is true or false, and reality is determinate: something is either the case or it is not. Interestingly, it is exactly this intuition that also provides suggestions for areas where bi-valence might not hold.

One such area is that of quantum phenomena. Attributions of properties such as spin to particles prior to measurement typically do not satisfy bi-valence. Since it is the measurement that forces a particle to have a certain spin, prior to measurement the assertion that it has that spin is still undefined, and so is its negation: quantum reality is not bi-valent. Hence, we need a different kind of logic here, specifically one in which (among others) the principle of excluded middle no longer holds.

Another area of reality that some have argued defies bi-valence, is not of a physical nature but more abstract: mathematics. According to constructivism, a mathematical entity with certain properties can be said to exist only if a constructive proof of its existence has been supplied. Before such a proof is available neither the assertion that the entity in question exists, nor its negation, the claim that it does not, can be said to be true or false. In constructivist (a.k.a. 'intuitionistic') logic the principle of excluded middle does *not* hold.

Other examples of domains for which people have argued that bi-valence is not a proper principle, include, e.g., the past: is any assertion about something in the past either true or false? If we assume that the past is fixed, determined, complete, then it seems that, yes, any assertion about it is either true or false, quite independent of our ability of ever finding out which of the two it is. But according to some that seems to misconstrue what assertions about the past want to express, and the role they have.

And then there is the future: are we willing to grant that every assertion about the future is either true or false? That seems to amount to acceptance of a strict form of determinism, which many find unacceptable.

Taking talk about the past as its lead, Michael Dummett famously formulated the following criterion for determining when one is committed to realism. Taking into account that realism is always relative to a particular domain, Dummett defined realism with respect to domain *X* as the commitment to use classical logic, including the principle of excluded middle, as the appropriate logic for assertions about *X*.[5]

[5] See Michael Dummett, 'Realism', in *Truth and Other Enigmas*, Duckworth, London, 1978.